

Shaped Like a Swimming Goldfish: Suo-Oshima and Its Emigrant Villages

Suo-Oshima's mountainous, sea-girt shape gave its people little farmland but centuries of seafaring skill. When Hawaii's plantations needed labor in 1885, nearly a third of Japan's first contract emigrants sailed from this one district. Remittances, a 1976 bridge and today's citrus orchards all trace back to that departure. This dossier follows the ground they left.



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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

Shaped like a swimming goldfish

Suo-Oshima lies at the eastern edge of Yamaguchi Prefecture, a sea-girt territory rather than a single island. A district history published in 1923 describes its shape as resembling a swimming goldfish, broad in the southwest and narrowing toward the northeast, made up of the main island of Yashiro and more than thirty smaller islands scattered around it, and gives its size as seven ri and thirty-one cho (about 31 km) from east to west and six ri and twenty-two cho (about 26 km) north to south, an area of just over fourteen square ri. A 1928 prefectural guide puts the same district's coastline, following every inlet, at some twenty-eight ri, or around 110 km, in all. Ehime Prefecture lies across the water to the east and south, and the hills of Hiroshima Prefecture are visible to the north, across Itsukushima and other islands; the mainland districts of Kuga and Kumage face the district across a narrow strait to the west. The 1923 history counts many mountains and little flat land, with three ranges radiating from the central peak, Mount Kano; what plains exist follow the short Yashiro River, which crosses the middle of Yashiro village on its way to the sea, and the even shorter Miyazaki River at Kuka.¹³

The 1923 history also repeats an old local claim: that the district was once its own province, Oshima-no-kuni, one of the 'great eight islands' of Japan's founding myths, before it was folded into Suo Province and survived only as a district name. Whatever its mythic status, the district was real enough to the powerful families, the Kono, Noshima, Kurushima, Murakami and Kuwahara among them, who held sway there through the late Muromachi period. Their independence ended in 1555, when Mori Motonari attacked the rival lord Sue Harukata at nearby Itsukushima; after that, the same history records, the island lords came under Mori command and the district became Mori territory.¹

War comes to the strait

The Mori domain governed the district through a local sub-administration, or saihan, created in 1651 with its seat at Kuka; the arrangement was briefly abolished and restored again within a few years in the early eighteenth century, but Kuka remained the district's administrative center for the next two centuries.¹

Elsewhere on the island, roughly contemporary private initiative reshaped the coast on a smaller scale. A domain retainer named Awaya Tatewaki, granted the tidal shoals off Komatsu in the 1680s, spent seven years damming the tide to lay out salt fields there, then a further six years building a harbor and a marketplace; a memorial inscription recorded in the district's own 1935 local-history compendium credits this work with founding the reclaimed 'Kaisaku' quarter of Komatsu that is still on the map today. It was this kind of small-scale land-making, salt pans, harbor works and reclaimed fields, that supported a slowly growing population before the nineteenth century opened a very different outlet overseas.²

The old order ended, abruptly, in July 1866 (the sixth month by the old calendar), during the Second Choshu Expedition. Shogunate and allied forces occupied Kuka and Ageno-sho; a prefectural guidebook published two generations later still remembered Kuka as a place 'washed in fire and blood' by the fighting. Takasugi Shinsaku boarded the Choshu warship Heiin-maru for a night raid on the shogunate fleet on the 13th day of that month (24 July); two days later Choshu troops landed on the island and, after several days of fighting, drove the occupiers back to their ships. With Kuka burned, the district's administrative seat moved to Yashiro village, where it remained until 1896.¹³⁶¹⁴

One casualty of the same campaign became, briefly, a figure of national history: Sera Shuzo, born in the district's Mukuno village in 1835, took up arms to help repel the 1866 attack on Oshima, then served the new imperial government as a staff officer during the Boshin War. Sent north in 1868 as part of the effort to pacify the Aizu domain, he was captured and killed by Sendai and Fukushima domain soldiers at the age of 32; his death is remembered today as the spark that pushed the northern domains into their alliance against the government he served.²¹⁵

The mountains that could not feed everyone

Meiji administration confirmed what geography had already decided. Yashiro's turn as district seat ended in 1896, when the office returned to Kuka; by 1920, the district's own statistical yearbook counted 81,643 people across its towns and villages. Citrus growing, which today occupies much of the island's slopes, was already under way by then: the modern town's own account traces cultivation's beginnings to the late Edo period. But the mountainous terrain the 1923 history described left little room for fields to begin with, and a growing population on a hilly, sea-locked group of islands had, by the late nineteenth century, few local ways to make a better living.¹⁴⁹

The 1920 population figures hint at how unevenly the district's towns had grown: Ageno-sho, with its sheltered harbor, counted over 11,000 people, more than either Kuka or Yashiro. Heigun, a separate island community of about 4,000 reachable only by boat, was different again: a 1928 guidebook describes most of its people as descended from the Mori domain's old ship crews. It was from villages across this whole district, not only Kuka and Yashiro, that the movement overseas would draw its numbers.³⁴

To Hawaii and beyond

The opening came from abroad. In 1885, after Japan and the Kingdom of Hawaii agreed on a program of contract labor for the islands' sugar plantations, the ship *City of Tokio* carried the first 944 emigrants into Honolulu on 8 February. About three in ten of them, by the count the Japan-Hawaii Emigration Museum now gives, came from this one district. Over the following nine years of government-contract emigration, to 1894, some 3,913 people left Suo-Oshima for Hawaii, about 13.5 percent of the entire national total of roughly 29,000 contract emigrants, an extraordinary share for a single rural district of one prefecture.^{10 11 16}

The human cost showed quickly. A travel account of Hawaii published in 1889, only four years after the first ship, includes a necrology of Japanese who had already died there, among them people from several of the district's villages, Yashiro included. By the early 1920s the district's own records show its people no longer traveling only to Hawaii: its statistical yearbook lists departures and returns to and from the US mainland, Canada, Peru, Brazil, the Philippines, Mexico, Australia, Singapore and Java, evidence of a diaspora that had, within two generations, spread far beyond the sugar plantations where it began.^{4 5}

What the money built

By 1928 the effect on the district was plain enough to print in a prefectural guidebook: many of the district's residents, it reported, worked abroad, and the whole district earned more than three million yen a year from it, so that all the islanders lived comfortably. One emigrant's story survives in brick and timber: Fukumoto Chouemon, born in Yashiro village in 1881, left alone for the United States at sixteen, made his fortune in trade, and returned to Suo-Oshima in 1924. Four years later he built a substantial house mixing Japanese and Western styles, at a cost the museum that now occupies it puts at some 30,000 yen, a considerable sum at the time.³¹⁰

That house still stands in Nishi-Yashiro, at the center of this dossier's district. In 2022 it was added to the national register of tangible cultural properties, and since 1999 it has held the Japan-Hawaii Emigration Museum, opened on 8 February, the anniversary of the *City of Tokio*'s arrival. Among its exhibits is material related to King Kalakaua of Hawaii's 1881 visit to Japan, part of the diplomatic background to the emigration program that began four years later.^{10 11}

Bridge, orchard and sister island

Ties to Hawaii outlasted the emigration itself. In June 1963 the head of the Oshima district's association of town mayors traveled to Kauai and signed a sister-island agreement with the county there, formalizing a relationship rooted in the district's own history of emigration to Hawaii. Exchange visits followed: high-school students went to a Kauai summer school from

1964, and in 1985 four Oshima town mayors and assembly chairs traveled to Hawaii for the centennial of the government-contract emigration itself, an anniversary marked two years later by a monument unveiled at Kauai's newly opened Lihue airport. The relationship's own fiftieth anniversary was marked by a ceremony at Kauai's county offices in October 2013.⁷

In 1976, thirteen years into that relationship, the island's isolation from the mainland ended for good: the Oshima Bridge, a 1,020-meter span engineered with an unusual multi-column foundation to resist the strait's fast tidal currents, opened on 4 July, fulfilling what a prefectural tourism account calls a wish old enough to have been sung about in folk songs, and what a fiftieth-anniversary newspaper retrospective still described as a bridge that carried the islanders' happiness.¹²¹³

The island's local government caught up with these changes in 2004, when Kuka, Oshima, Towa and Tachibana, the four towns that had divided the old district between them, merged into a single Suo-Oshima Town. Citrus growing, which the town's own account traces to the late Edo period, has continued on the island's hillsides ever since, a slower, steadier transformation of the same mountainous ground that once pushed so many of its people overseas.⁸⁹

Reading the ground today

At the center of this district's study area, in Nishi-Yashiro, the Fukumoto house that Chouemon built with his American earnings still stands, its museum rooms arranged around the life he and thousands of his neighbors made abroad. The short Yashiro River, named in the 1923 district history as the area's largest stream, still runs down from the island's interior past Yashiro village to the sea nearby, much as it did when the first emigrants left. On the hillsides around it, citrus orchards, a much younger planting than the district's old rice and dry fields but grown here since the late Edo period, climb the slopes that the 1923 source described as leaving little room for fields.¹⁹

From the shore near the museum, the view north across the water toward Hiroshima Prefecture is close to what the 1923 district history describes from this side of the island. The Oshima Bridge, a short drive west of Nishi-Yashiro, is worth the detour: before it opened in 1976, this strait was the only way on or off the island, and from its pedestrian walkway the fast tidal currents that shaped that isolation are still visible, racing beneath the deck.¹¹³

Timeline

1555	Mori Motonari's victory over Sue Harukata at Itsukushima brings the island's powerful families under Mori control. ¹
1651	The Mori domain creates the Oshima saihan sub-administration, seated at Kuka. ¹
July 1866	Shogunate and allied forces occupy Kuka and Ageno-sho during the Second Choshu Expedition; after Takasugi Shinsaku's raid aboard the Heiin-maru on 24 July (the 13th day of the sixth month by the old calendar), Choshu forces retake the island from 26 July. ¹³⁶¹⁴
1866-1896	After Kuka is burned, the district's administrative seat moves to Yashiro village; a county office is formally established there in 1879, then moved to Kuka in 1896. ¹
1868	Sera Shuzo, born in the district's Mukuno village, is killed in the Boshin War at age 32. ²
8 February 1885	The ship City of Tokio carries the first 944 government-contract emigrants to Honolulu; about three in ten are from Oshima District. ¹⁰¹¹¹⁶
1885-1894	Some 3,913 people leave Suo-Oshima for Hawaii under the government-contract emigration program. ¹⁰
1920	The district's population reaches 81,643; official figures also record departures to the US mainland, Canada, Peru, Brazil, the Philippines and beyond. ⁴
1928	Fukumoto Chouemon, returned from the United States, builds the house in Nishi-Yashiro that later becomes the emigration museum. ¹⁰
June 1963	Suo-Oshima and Hawaii's Kauai formalize a sister-island relationship. ⁷
4 July 1976	The Oshima Bridge opens, ending the island's dependence on ferries to the mainland. ¹²¹³
8 February 1999	The Japan-Hawaii Emigration Museum opens in the former Fukumoto residence, on the anniversary of the City of Tokio's arrival. ¹⁰
1 October 2004	Kuka, Oshima, Towa and Tachibana towns merge to form Suo-Oshima Town. ⁸

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1

Japan-Hawaii Emigration Museum 日本ハワイ移民資料館. The 1928 Fukumoto residence, built with money its owner made in the United States; now a national Registered Tangible Cultural Property holding the district's own account of the Hawaii emigration.¹⁰¹¹
- 2

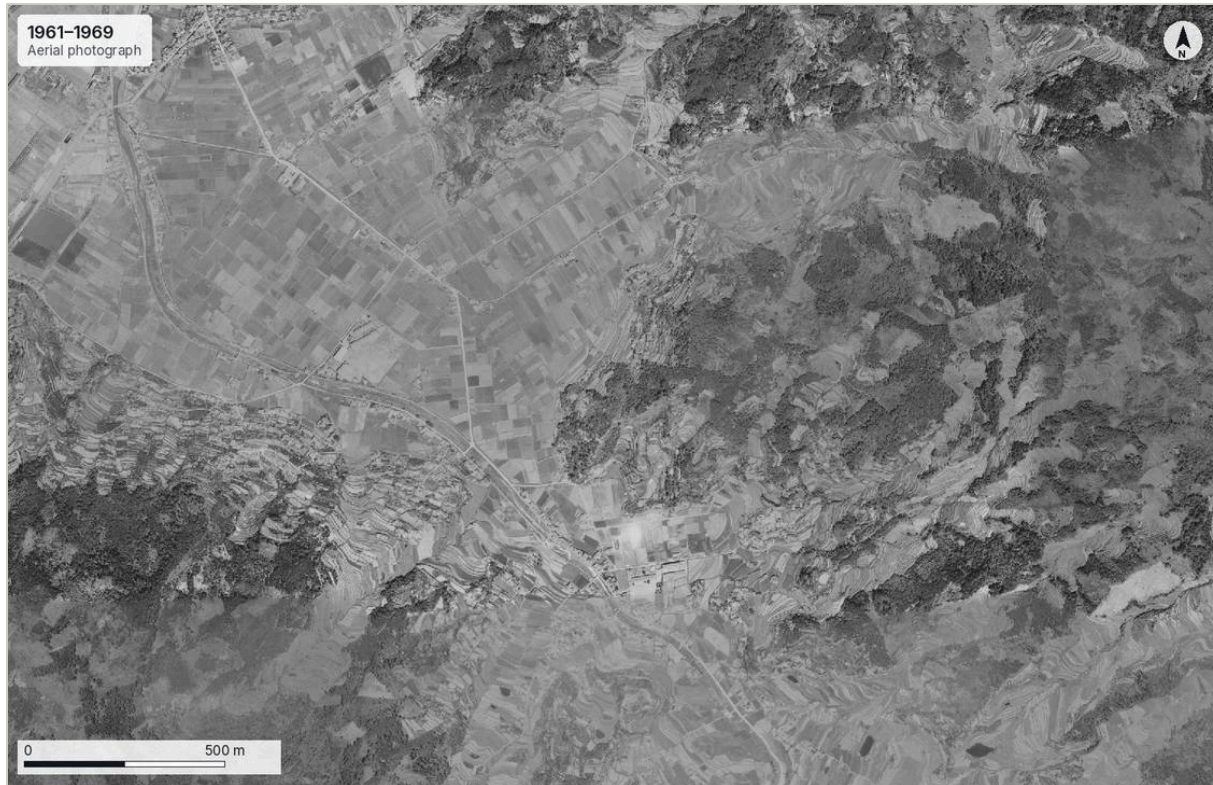
Yashiro River 屋代川. The area's largest river by the 1923 district history's own account, running from the island's interior to the sea past Yashiro village.¹
- 3

Hillside citrus orchards みかん畑. Citrus orchards on the slopes around Higashi- and Nishi-Yashiro, a crop the town traces to the late Edo period and grown ever since on ground the 1923 district history called too steep for fields.¹⁹
- 4

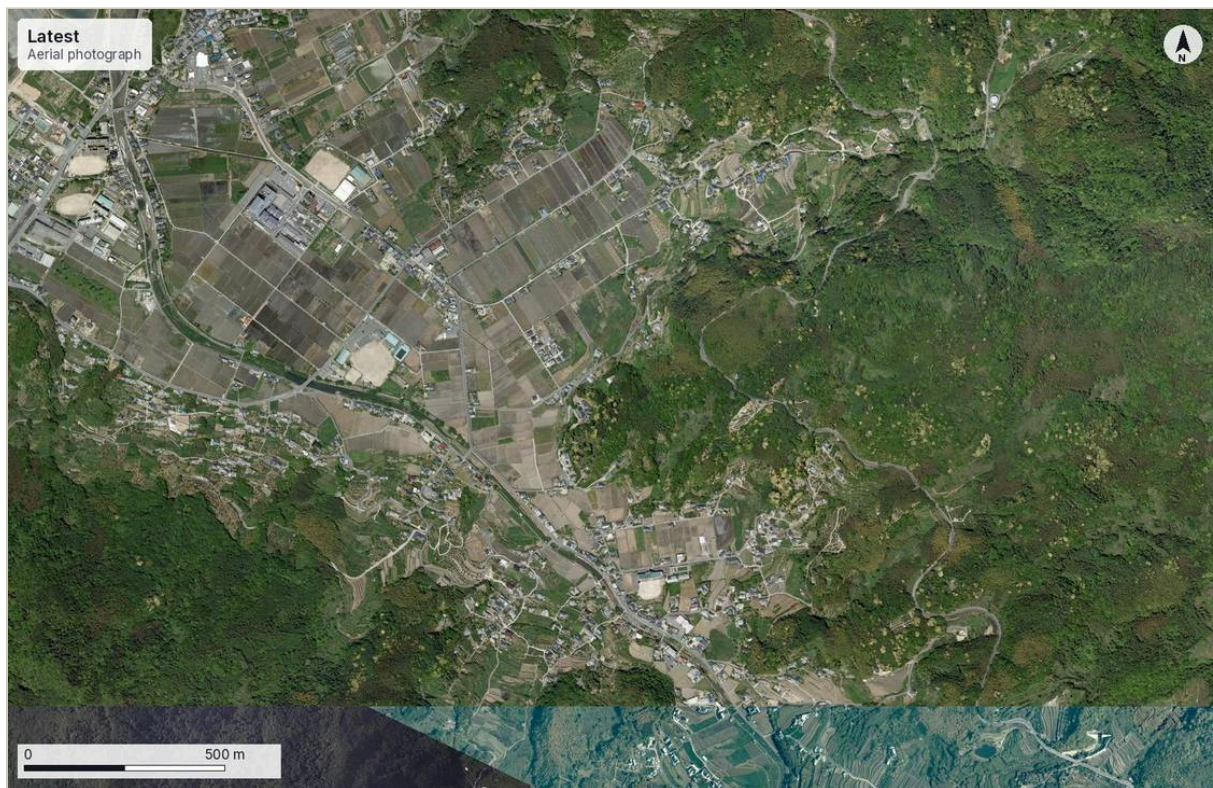
The shore at Higashi-Yashiro 東屋代の海岸. A shoreline view north toward Hiroshima Prefecture across the water, the same outlook the 1923 district history describes from this side of the island.¹
- 5

Oshima Bridge 大島大橋. A short drive west, the 1,020-meter bridge that ended the island's ferry-only isolation in 1976; its walkway looks down on the fast tidal currents of the Obatake Strait.¹³

The same ground, 1961–1969 and today



1961–1969 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



Latest seamless mosaic — GSI Tiles *seamlessphoto*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

The decades in between

Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1974–1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed



1979–1983 · GSI Tiles *gazo2*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.



GSI has no detailed landform survey for this frame, so the map uses GSI's regional classification (compiled for zoom levels 9–13). It shows the broad landform only; former river channels and man-made ground are not mapped at that scale.

What the main landforms mean

Mountains (61%). Terrain of high ridges and valleys. Watch for slope disasters.

Lowland (30%). Flat land built from sand, gravel and mud laid down by rivers or the sea. River flooding, storm surge and liquefaction; shakes easily in earthquakes.

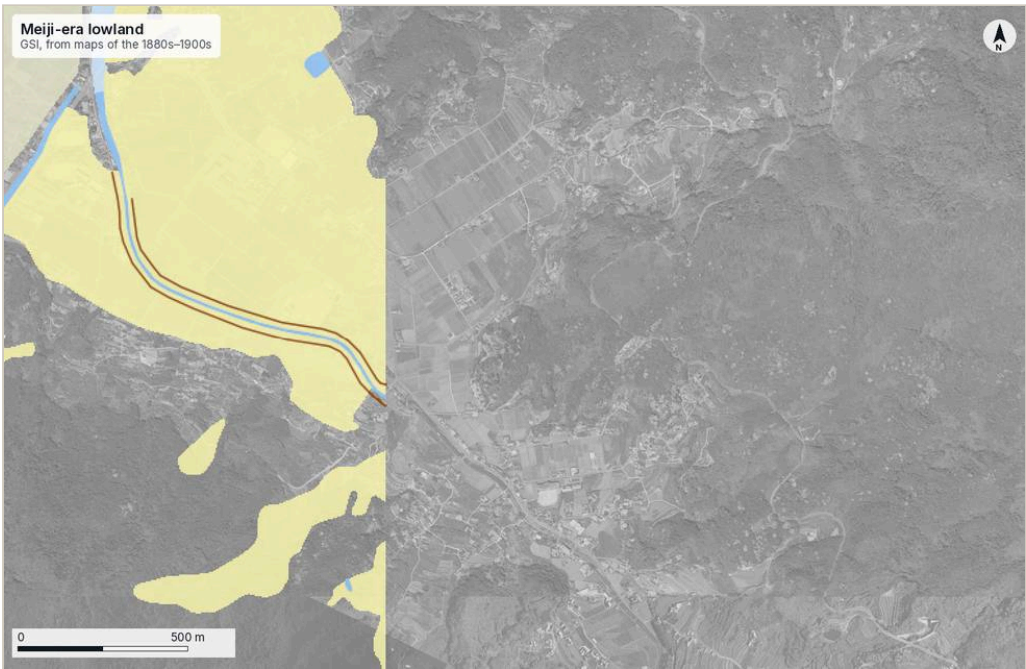
Residual hills (buttes) (8.6%). Isolated rocky peaks or table-like hills of old volcanic rock. Rockfall and slope failures on the surrounding cliffs.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s–1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

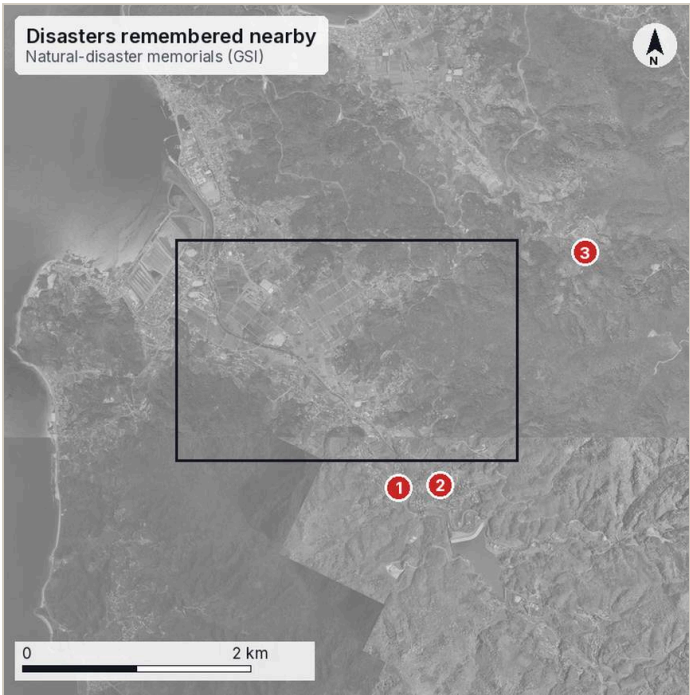
Man-made ground

No man-made ground mapped in this frame.

Meiji-era lowland

- Rice paddy 17%
- Salt pans 1.3%
- River, pond or sea under 0.5%

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 6 km across.

Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1 Monument to the 1886 Gonotsubo flood disaster 罹災之碑	Great Gonotsubo flood (24 Sep 1886) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1889	1.3 km
2 Memorial to the 110 people killed in the 1886 Gonotsubo flood 弔百十名之霊	Great Gonotsubo flood (24 Sep 1886) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1887	1.4 km
3 Monument to the 1893 flood of the Migama River 水災之碑	Flood (14 Oct 1893) · flood / landslide or debris flow	unknown	2.3 km

What the memorials record

1. **Monument to the 1886 Gonotsubo flood disaster.** Heavy rain every day from about 20 September 1886 set off a landslide that blocked the Kubo River. At 5 pm on the 24th the natural dam burst, and the debris flow killed 110 people in Gonotsubo and buried 62 houses. The inscription notes that the mountain had also collapsed in 1333 and that preventive measures are needed.
2. **Memorial to the 110 people killed in the 1886 Gonotsubo flood.** Heavy rain every day from about 20 September 1886 set off a landslide that blocked the Kubo River and formed a natural dam. At 5 pm on the 24th the dam burst, and the debris flow killed 110 people in Gonotsubo and buried 62 houses.
3. **Monument to the 1893 flood of the Migama River.** On 14 October 1893, after five days of rain, Mount Monju collapsed and the Migama River overflowed. The flood killed 23 people and swept away 16 houses in the former village of Kamano.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

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2. 山口県大島郡小学校教育会 (Oshima District Elementary School Teachers' Association, Yamaguchi Prefecture), *大島郡郷土調査* [A local survey of Oshima District], 1935; NDL frames 348, 349. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1259775/1/348> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Inscriptions on the district's own 1866-campaign war memorial and on the memorial stele to Sera Shuzo, giving his birthplace, career and 1868 death, and framing it as a trigger for the northern domains' alliance.
3. 鴻陽新報社 (Koyo Shimpō-sha), *史蹟名勝山口県案内* [A guide to the historic and scenic sites of Yamaguchi Prefecture], 1928; NDL frames 109, 110. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1176938/1/109> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: The district's emigration-remittance economy ('three million yen a year'); Kuka's size and its 1866 war damage; Heigun Island's economy and Mori-era ship-crew ancestry.
4. 山口県大島郡 (Oshima District, Yamaguchi Prefecture), *山口県大島郡勢要覧大正9年* [Statistical overview of Oshima District, Yamaguchi Prefecture, 1920], 1922; NDL frame 23. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/912951/1/23> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: 1920 population by town and village (total 81,643) and the list of overseas destination countries recorded for departures and returns.
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6. 「四境の役・大島口の戦い」戦跡&史跡ガイドマップ [Guide map: battle sites of the Oshima front, Second Choshu Expedition], 周防大島町 (Suo-Oshima Town). <https://www.town.suo-oshima.lg.jp/uploaded/attachment/13779.pdf>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Dated timeline of the June 1866 campaign, including Takasugi Shinsaku's counter-attack aboard the Heiin-maru.
7. 広報すおう大島 平成25年(2013年)11月号：周防大島町・カウアイ島姉妹島提携50周年記念式典 [Koho Suo-Oshima, November 2013: the Suo-Oshima/Kauai sister-island 50th-anniversary ceremony], 周防大島町 (Suo-Oshima Town). <https://www.town.suo-oshima.lg.jp/uploaded/attachment/8503.pdf>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Date (June 1963) and circumstances of the sister-island agreement, signed by the Oshima-gun mayors' association chairman; the visit and exchange timeline to the October 2013 anniversary ceremony.
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11. 日本ハワイ移民資料館 [The Japan-Hawaii Emigration Museum], 周防大島町 (Suo-Oshima Town). <https://www.town.suo-oshima.lg.jp/soshiki/27/1740.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The Fukumoto residence's 2022 registration as a national tangible cultural property; museum exhibit material related to King Kalakaua's 1881 visit to Japan.
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Further reading

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- 周防大島町誌 (大島町誌編纂委員会編, 1959) — The town's own official history compendium, the natural starting point for a fuller village-by-village account. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9574049> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 大島郡風景と人物 (迫村英一編, 1929) — A late-1920s portrait of the district's places and notable people, useful for local color and named individuals. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1112256> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 日本移民の地理学的研究：沖縄・広島・山口 (石川友紀著, 1997) — A scholarly geographical study of emigration from Okinawa, Hiroshima and Yamaguchi, with dedicated Oshima District analysis around frames 161-168; NDL premises only. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/13905031> (NDL premises only)
- 布哇同胞発展回顧誌：日布時事創刊二十五周年記念 (日布時事編輯局編, 1921) — A 25th-anniversary retrospective by a Hawaii-Japanese newspaper on emigrants' lives and success stories, including Oshima natives. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/12971962> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- Passport and emigration registers for named individuals and households from specific Oshima District villages** — Diplomatic Archives of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (外務省外交史料館). Search the archives' catalogue by village name and year; contract-emigration passport applications from the 1880s-90s are held there.
- Family-level remittance and return-migration records for the district** — Yamaguchi Prefectural Archives and the Suo-Oshima Town local-history section. Request access to surviving village office (yakuba) records and the underlying sources of 大島郡会史 and 大島郡郷土調査.
- Individual-name searches in the museum's own kan'yaku imin and free-emigration databases** — Japan-Hawaii Emigration Museum, Nishi-Yashiro. Visit in person or contact the museum directly; its database reportedly covers a large number of named emigrants.
- The Hawaii side of the story: plantation labor contracts, arrival registers and cemetery records for Oshima-born laborers** — Hawaii State Archives and the University of Hawaii's Japanese-American collections. Search by ship name (City of Tokio) and arrival date; several plantation and immigration-station records have been digitized.
- Fuller detail on the 1866 Oshima-guchi campaign and its casualties village by village** — Yamaguchi Prefectural Archives (山口県文書館) and Choshu-related military records. Search for 大島口の戦い and 第二奇兵隊 in the archives' catalogue; the town's own guide map (S6) is a starting index of sites.

Caveats

- Kuka, the district's historic administrative and commercial hub and the site of most of the 1866 battle's surviving landmarks, lies several kilometers from the Nishi-Yashiro study center of this dossier; it is discussed here as district-wide context, and the walk below is kept to points verified at or very near the study center.
- The 1923 district history's identification of Oshima District with 'Oshima-no-kuni,' one of the mythic 'great eight islands' of Japan's founding stories, is that source's own traditional claim rather than a settled scholarly identification, and is reported here as such.
- Emigration totals differ slightly between sources; this dossier follows the Japan-Hawaii Emigration Museum's own published figures (944 on the first ship, 3,913 from Suo-Oshima in 1885-94).
- A 1920 statistical table of yearly departures and returns by destination country could be read for its list of countries but not reliably for exact yearly counts, since OCR could not confirm the alignment of columns and rows; this dossier therefore reports only the population totals and the list of destinations from that source.
- The individual named in Suo-Oshima's own 2013 newsletter as having signed the 1963 Kauai agreement is not repeated here by name, since this dossier could not independently verify the correct romanization of his personal name from the source alone.

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